



BE READY.

Pre-season

Your sessions

Muscle development + Fitness

Program

Pre-season

Duration

8 weeks

Session

45 to 60 min

Place

Gym

For personal use only, do not share. This program is for people in good health: if you feel pain, have an injury or are in doubt, stop and ask a health professional for advice.

Your goals

Muscle development

In handball, you take contacts in every attack and every defence. Stronger muscles protect your joints and make you harder to knock off balance.

- **Strength:** pushing, pulling and lifting heavier.
- **Mass gain:** building muscle size.
- **Core and stability:** transferring force from your legs to your arm and staying stable in contacts.

The golden rules

- **Technique first:** a load only goes up if the movement stays clean.
- **Progress a little every week:** one more rep, or a slightly heavier load.
- **Control the descent:** 2 to 3 seconds down, then back up with energy.
- Keep 2 to 3 reps in reserve: never train to failure.

Mass gain: training sends the signal, but muscles are built with food and sleep. Eat enough, with protein at every meal, and sleep 8 hours. For nutrition advice, see a registered dietitian.

Fitness

During a match, players cover about 4 km on average, alternating walking, running, sprints and contacts (Wagner et al., 2014). What makes the difference at the end of a game is the ability to repeat intense efforts and recover quickly between them.

- **Endurance:** the base that lets you recover between actions.
- **Repeated effort capacity:** stringing sprints together without losing speed.
- **Fat loss:** increasing energy expenditure while keeping your performance.
- **General fitness:** lasting a whole match and a whole season.

The golden rules

- **Progressive:** the volume goes up week after week, never all at once.
- **Stick to the paces:** easy = you can talk; steady = a few words; hard = impossible to talk.
- On repeated sprints, stop the set if your speed drops clearly.

Fat loss: training increases energy expenditure, but the result depends mostly on food and sleep. Avoid restrictive diets, which lower performance. For support, see a registered dietitian.

When three durations are given ("12-15-18 min"), they are for levels 1, 2 and 3.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

How to read your sessions

- Every session is written out in full, in order: do the steps from top to bottom.
- "2-4 × 8": 2 sets at level 1, 3 at level 2, 4 at level 3, of 8 reps. "2-3 × 8": 2 sets at levels 1 and 2, 3 at level 3.
- The number in front of each exercise refers to its illustrated sheet, at the end of this document.
- If you do not know your level, read the guide again, page "Choosing your level".

Weeks 1-2 · Getting started

Get your body used to effort again and learn the movements. Effort 5-6 out of 10.

Muscle development: light loads, learning the movements.

Fitness: build your endurance base, gently.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

9	 Squat	2-3 × 10	75 s
10	 Dumbbell bench press	2-3 × 10	60 s

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

11	Easy run	12-15-18 min	
12	 High knees	4 × 15 m	walk back

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

15	 Romanian deadlift	2-3 × 10	75 s
16	 Row	2-3 × 10	60 s
17	 Pallof press	2 × 10 per side	30 s

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

18	 Circuit training	2-3 rounds	90 s between rounds
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4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

19	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
20	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
21	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

22	 Reverse lunge	2-3 × 8 per leg	60 s
23	 Shoulder press	2-3 × 10	60 s

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

11	Easy run	10-12-15 min	
24	15-15 intervals (introduction)	4-5-6 min	

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

25	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
26	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
27	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Week after week, you can add the optional bonus session:

Session D (bonus, optional) - 20 min

1 WARM-UP

10 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 PREVENTION AND MOBILITY

10 min

5	 Plank	2 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2 × 3	60 s
28	 90/90 hip mobility	1 × 8 per side	
29	 Ankle mobility at the wall	1 × 10 per side	
30	 Upper back rotation	1 × 8 per side	

Weeks 3-5 - Building up

Increase the loads gradually. Week 5 is the heaviest. Effort 7-8 out of 10.

Muscle development: this is the key phase, increase the loads every week. If your goal is mass gain, do 8 to 12 reps with 60 to 90 s of rest.

Fitness: intervals come in.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

9	 Squat	3-4 × 6-8	2 min
10	 Dumbbell bench press	3-4 × 8	90 s
31	 Farmer's walk	3 × 20 m	60 s

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

24	15-15 intervals	2 × 6-7-8 min	3 min between blocks
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4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

32	 Hip thrust	3-4 × 8	90 s
33	 Pull-ups (or row)	3-4 × 6-8	90 s
17	 Pallof press	3 × 10 per side	30 s

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

18	 Circuit training	3-4 rounds	90 s between rounds
34	Handball shuttles	4 × 30 s	30 s

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

19	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
20	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
21	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP		10-12 min	
1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back
2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT		15-20 min	
35	 Bulgarian split squat	3 × 8 per leg	90 s
15	 Romanian deadlift	3 × 8	90 s
23	 Shoulder press	3 × 8	75 s
3 FITNESS		15-20 min	
11	Easy run	15-18-20 min	
36	30-30 intervals	6-8-10 reps	
4 CORE AND PREVENTION		5-8 min	
25	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
26	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
27	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s
5 COOL-DOWN		5 min	
2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.			

Weeks 6-7 · Intensity

Less volume, more speed: every rep at maximum quality. Effort 7-8 out of 10.

Muscle development: fewer sets, loads still heavy.

Fitness: short, repeated efforts, like in a match.

Session A

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

9	 Squat	3 × 5	2 min
10	 Dumbbell bench press	3 × 8	75 s

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

37	Repeated sprints	2-3 sets	3 min
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4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

5	 Plank	2-4 × 30 s	30 s
13	 Side plank	2-3 × 20 s per side	20 s
14	 Nordic hamstring curl	2-3 × 4	60 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session B

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

32	 Hip thrust	3 × 6	90 s
33	 Pull-ups (or row)	3 × 6	90 s

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

24	15-15 intervals	2 × 8 min	3 min
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4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

19	 Dead bug	2-3 × 8 per side	30 s
20	 Y-T-W	2-3 × 8	30 s
21	 Balance with a ball	2 × 30 s per leg	20 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Session C

1 WARM-UP

10-12 min

1	Light jog and running drills	3 min	
2	 Forward lunge with trunk rotation	6 per side	
3	 Walking hip opener	8 per side	
4	 Glute bridge	2 × 10	15 s
5	 Plank	2 × 20 s	15 s
6	 Single-leg balance	2 × 20 s per leg	
7	 Small jump, stable landing	2 × 5	20 s
8	Progressive accelerations	3 runs	walk back

2 MUSCLE DEVELOPMENT

15-20 min

22	 Reverse lunge	3 × 6 per leg	90 s
17	 Pallof press	2 × 10 per side	30 s

3 FITNESS

15-20 min

34	Handball shuttles	6 × 30 s	30 s
11	Easy run (recovery)	10 min	

4 CORE AND PREVENTION

5-8 min

25	 Single-leg glute bridge	2-3 × 10 per leg	30 s
26	 Copenhagen plank (knee version)	2-3 × 15 s per side	30 s
27	 Shoulder external rotation	2-3 × 12 per arm	30 s

5 COOL-DOWN

5 min

2 minutes of walking, then light stretches of 20 to 30 seconds, without forcing: hip flexors, quads, hamstrings, calves, chest and shoulders.

Week 8 - Taper

Repeat sessions A, B and C from weeks 6-7 doing **half the sets**, at the same intensity. You will start the season with your club in top shape.

- **Muscle development:** Same loads.
- **Fitness:** Halve the duration or the number of sets, keep the intensity.

The exercises

In the order of the numbers used in your sessions.



Important: watch each exercise's animation before doing it. Tap the eye next to its name. The animation shows what the text cannot: the exact position, the direction of the movement, the rhythm and the footwork. Do not just read the program, especially for an exercise you do not know: this is what makes every session effective and safe.

1 Light jog and running drills

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: light jog, then running drills (high knees, butt kicks). Otherwise: drills on the spot or in the gym's open space: 5 minutes of high knees, butt kicks and side shuffles.

Key points: Start slowly, then gradually pick up the pace.



2



Forward lunge with trunk rotation

Take a big step forward, lower into a lunge, then turn your trunk towards the front leg. Come back and switch legs.

Key points: Front knee above the ankle, slow rotation.



3



Walking hip opener

As you walk, lift your knee out to the side as if stepping over a fence, bring it round in front of you at the same height, and put your foot down one step further. Switch legs.

Key points: Upright trunk, big circle with the knee.



4



Glute bridge

On your back, knees bent, feet on the floor, lift your hips until shoulders, hips and knees are in line, then lower.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes at the top, do not arch your lower back. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



5



Plank

On your forearms and toes, body in a straight line from head to heels.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes and abs, breathe normally.

Easier: Knees on the floor.



6 Single-leg balance

On one foot, knee slightly bent, arms relaxed: hold the position without moving. To progress: close your eyes, then stand on a cushion.

Key points: The knee stays over the foot, the pelvis level.



7 Small jump, stable landing

Small jump on the spot, land softly on both feet and hold the position for 2 seconds.

Key points: Land on the balls of your feet, knees bent and in line with your toes: they never cave inwards. In the air, pull your toes up towards your shins (locked ankle), ready for the landing.

8 **Progressive accelerations**

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: 3 accelerations of 5 seconds, faster each time. Otherwise: 3 accelerations of 10 seconds on an assault bike (air bike) or a rowing machine.

Key points: Relaxed, shoulders loose.

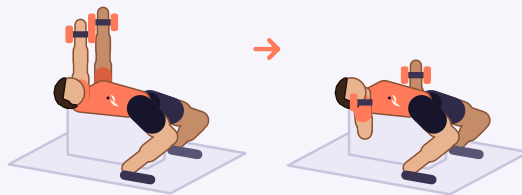


9 Squat

Feet shoulder-width apart, a dumbbell held against your chest (goblet squat), lower until your thighs are at least parallel to the floor, then stand up. Heavier: barbell on your upper back.

Key points: Straight back, heels on the floor, knees in line with your feet.

Easier: Sit down on a chair and stand up.



10 Dumbbell bench press

Lying on a bench, a dumbbell in each hand, lower the dumbbells to chest level, elbows at 45°, then push.

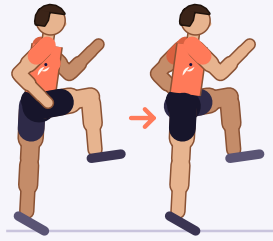
Key points: Elbows at 45° from your body, the hips do not sag.

Easier: Push-ups, hands on a bench.

11 Easy run

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: continuous running at a pace where you can talk. Otherwise: motorised treadmill, bike or cross-trainer, at the same intensity and for the same time.

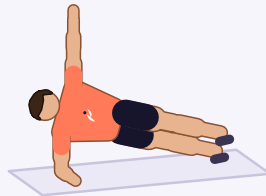
Key points: If you cannot talk, slow down or alternate running and walking.



12 High knees

Over 15 m, drive your knees up quickly as you move forward.

Key points: On the balls of your feet, active arms.

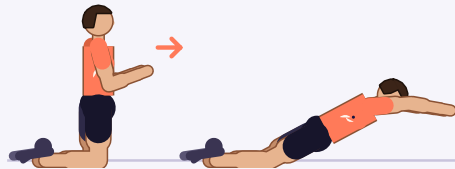


13 Side plank

On your side, on one forearm and the edge of your foot, body in line, hips high.

Key points: The hips do not drop.

Easier: Knees on the floor.

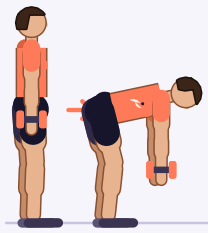


14 Nordic hamstring curl

Kneeling on a mat, feet anchored under a loaded bench, under wall bars or held by another person, lean forward as slowly as possible, body straight. Catch yourself with your hands, then push back up with your hands.

Key points: Hips extended: the body stays straight from the knees to the head.

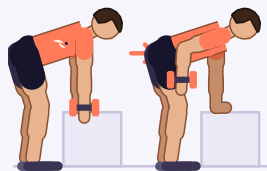
Easier: Shorter descent.



15 Romanian deadlift

Knees slightly bent, a barbell or two dumbbells in your hands, tip your trunk forward by pushing your hips back, flat back, then stand up.

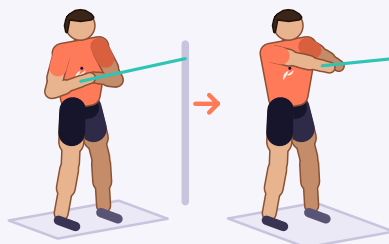
Key points: Flat back from start to finish, the load slides along your legs.



16 Row

Trunk bent forward, flat back, free hand on a bench: pull a dumbbell towards your hip. Other option: seated cable row.

Key points: Pull with your back, the shoulder blade moves towards the spine.

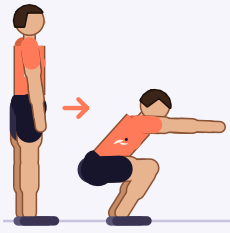


17 Pallof press

On a cable set at chest height (or with a band), side-on: press your arms out in front of you without letting your trunk rotate, hold for 2 seconds.

Key points: Resist the rotation: this is a core exercise.

Squats



Push-ups



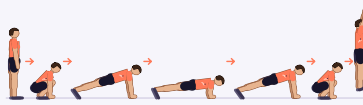
Alternating lunges



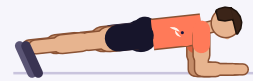
Mountain climbers



Burpees



Plank



18 Circuit training

30 seconds of each exercise in a row: squats, push-ups, alternating lunges, mountain climbers, burpees, plank.

Key points: Quality of movement before speed.

Easier: 20 seconds of work, 10 seconds of rest.



19 Dead bug

On your back, arms straight up towards the ceiling, knees bent at 90°. Extend one arm and the opposite leg without touching the floor, then switch sides.

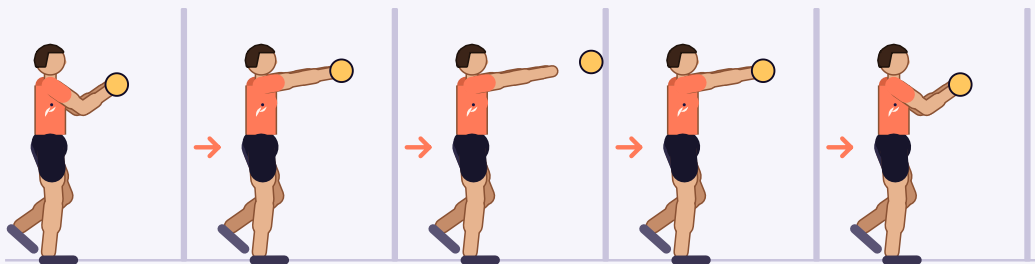
Key points: Your lower back stays pressed to the floor.



20 Y-T-W

Lying face down, forehead on a towel. Lift your arms off the floor to draw three letters with your body: Y (arms straight, diagonally above your head), T (arms out to the sides), then W (elbows bent, pulled in close to your ribs). Hold each letter for 2 seconds, squeezing your shoulder blades.

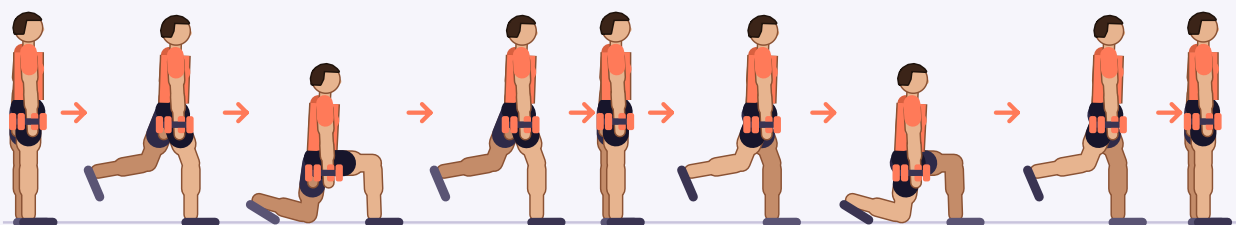
Key points: Thumbs towards the ceiling, no arching.



21 Balance with a ball

On one leg, on a bosu or a wobble board, throw a ball against a wall and catch it.

Key points: The standing knee stays in line.

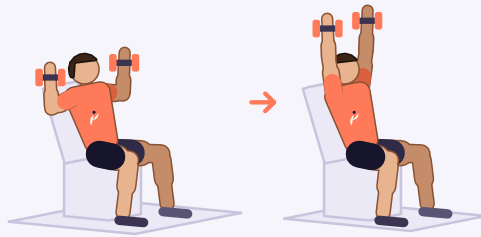


22 Reverse lunge

A dumbbell in each hand, step one leg back and lower until the back knee almost touches the floor, then come back by pushing through the front leg and switch legs (the front foot stays planted).

Key points: Upright trunk, front knee above the ankle.

Easier: With support (wall, chair).



23 Shoulder press

Seated on a bench, backrest inclined at 70°, back well supported: press the dumbbells overhead, then lower back to your shoulders.

Key points: Tight core, do not arch your lower back.

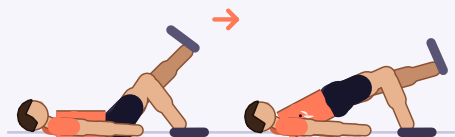
Easier: Pike push-ups (hips up).

24 15-15 intervals

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: same work and recovery times. Otherwise: assault bike (air bike) or rowing machine, with the same times.

Key points: Same distance on every rep: pick a finish point.

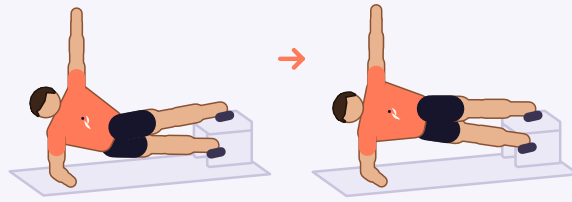
Easier: 15 seconds fast, 30 seconds of recovery.



25 Single-leg glute bridge

Like the glute bridge, with one leg straight in the air.

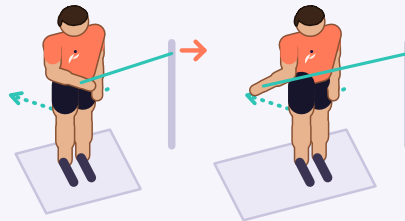
Key points: The pelvis stays level. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.



26 Copenhagen plank

On your side, on your forearm, top leg resting on a bench (at the knee, or at the foot to make it harder). Lift your hips and hold the position.

Key points: Body in line: the inside of the top thigh does the work.



27 Shoulder external rotation

On a cable set at elbow height (or with a band): elbow tucked in and bent at 90°, move your forearm outwards, then come back slowly.

Key points: The elbow does not move, 2 seconds on the way back.

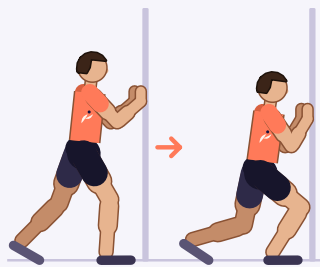
Easier: Without a band.



28 90/90 hip mobility

Seated on the floor, hands on the floor behind you, feet flat and wider than your hips, knees up. Let both knees drop to the same side into the 90/90 position: front leg bent at 90° in front of you, back leg bent at 90° out to the side. Bring the knees back up through the middle and over to the other side, like windscreen wipers.

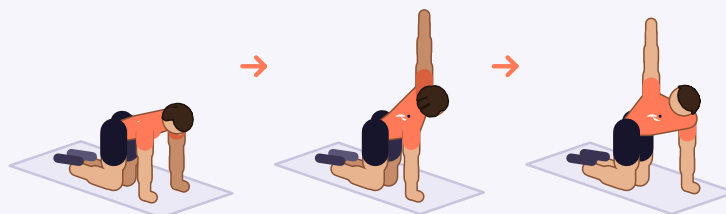
Key points: Upright trunk, slow movement. Only go as far as your hips allow, pain-free.



29 Ankle mobility at the wall

Facing a wall, foot 10 cm away, drive your knee forward to touch the wall without lifting your heel.

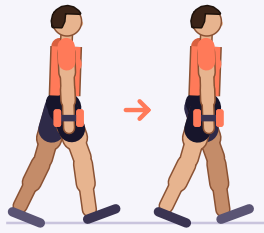
Key points: Heel glued to the floor. Move your foot back if it is easy.



30 Upper back rotation

On all fours, hands under your shoulders. Rotate your upper back as you reach one arm towards the ceiling, following your hand with your eyes, then bring it back down and do the same with the other arm.

Key points: The pelvis does not move.



31 Farmer's walk

Walk 20 m with a heavy dumbbell or kettlebell in each hand.

Key points: Shoulders down, upright trunk, steady steps.

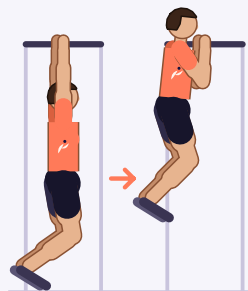


32 Hip thrust

Upper back against a bench, barbell (with a pad) or dumbbell on your hips, lift your hips until shoulders, hips and knees are in line.

Key points: Squeeze your glutes at the top for one second. Also contract your pelvic floor (as if holding in urine): it protects against leaks, especially for women and older people.

Easier: Glute bridge on the floor.



33 Pull-ups

Hanging from a bar, pull until your chin is over it, then lower. Other option: lat pulldown.

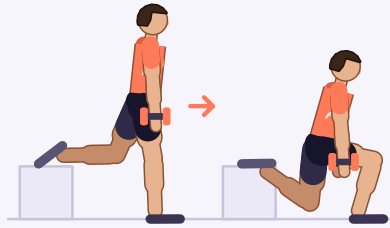
Key points: Controlled descent, arms almost straight at the bottom.

Easier: With a band or the assisted machine.

34 Handball shuttles

Back and forth between two lines 10 m apart: forwards, side shuffling and backwards.

Key points: Stay low in the changes of direction.



35 Bulgarian split squat

Back foot on a bench, a dumbbell in each hand, lower on the front leg then stand back up.

Key points: The front leg does the work, the back foot is only for balance.

36 30-30 intervals

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: same work and recovery times. Otherwise: assault bike (air bike) or rowing machine, with the same times.

Key points: Steady pace from one rep to the next.

37 Repeated sprints

On a **curved treadmill** (non-motorised, curved: you drive the belt yourself), if your gym has one: 6 sprints of 5 seconds, one start every 20 seconds. Otherwise: 6 sprints of 6 seconds on an assault bike, one start every 20 seconds.

Key points: Every sprint flat out.